CRAFTS

Combining beauty with utility

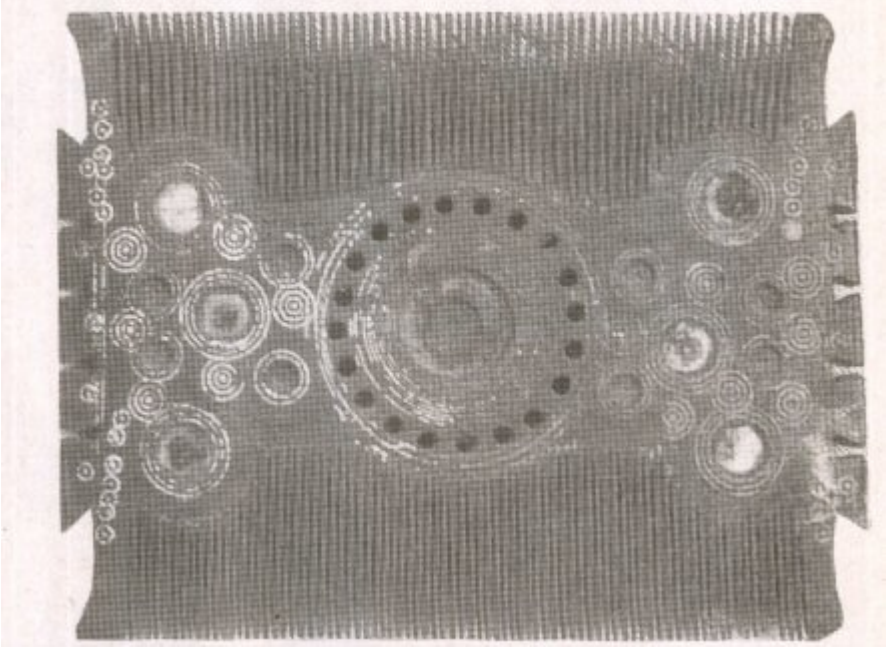
COMBS.... practical bare teeth to run through the hair.... In the flood of cheap plastic combs, there shine a few state-of-the-art ones. Some made of horns with carved, inlaid handles, some of wood with a container for oil to seep through the teeth as the comb is run through the hair... These exquisite creations were on display at the combmakers camp held recently by the Crafts Council of India at Rajagopal Polytechnic in Gudiatham. Comb makers from Andiappanoor, Tamil Nadu and Nare Bailu in Andhra Pradesh met to learn new techniques and artistic designs from the representatives of the design and technical development centre, Bangalore.

The wooden combs of Srikalahasti have suddenly zoomed into prominence and Sheik Abdul Razak, a master craftsman was there to show his techniques to the others and learn new designs of colouring.

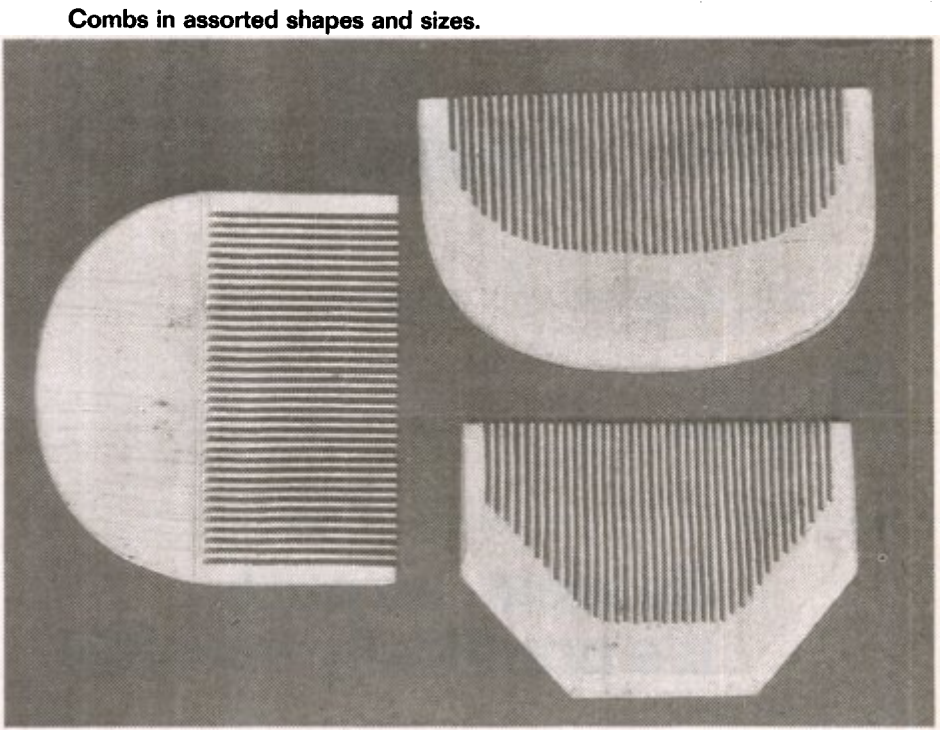
For a craftsman like Razak who spends all day carving fine teeth on wooden combs, and whose children have preferred to work as mechanics, drivers and tailors, the Crafts Council has come promotes the welfare of crafts communities including master craftsmen, trainees, apprentices and families of crafts persons by monitoring State and Central Government schemes and projects of nationalised banks.

The Crafts Council also seeks to give marketing support by identifying consumer needs which the craft activity can help to meet. "Sensitising participants in the craft sector to such a marketing approach would be a major responsibility", says Ms. Gita Ram, the CCI secretary. "Retail supports are also provided through craft exhibitions and sales periodically organised by the Crafts Council. Ms Gita Ram says," the CCI acts as a national crafts 'conscience' for India, an advocate of quality and integrity in the craft movement and a voice for the heritage of skills and communities which today face the challenges of transition."

The CCI is also in the process of organising craft information resources on an all India basis. It will be a data bank of information on craft skills, communities, resource, people funding



Combs in assorted shapes and sizes.



in as a great boon. He now attends camps around the country, has some of his products purchased in bulk by the Crafts Council and is in touch with other craftsmen.

It is not just the comb makers that the Crafts Council is interested in. In the last one year, the Council had conducted a survey of languishing crafts to diagnose problems of the trade and to prescribe remedies. The red Sanders jars and dolls, Udayagiri wooden cutlery, Killimangalam kora grass mats, coconut stem jars, Mysore paintings, Kinhal toys, Nagercoil temple jewellery, Salem Kalchattis.... all these crafts were surveyed, design inputs were given where necessary, specific orders were placed, and new products using traditional skills were developed.

Today's crafts have grown out of ancient traditions yet they now play either traditional or totally new roles. Crafts have always been an integral part of every day life. Historically they have not been seen as separate or minor arts as they are today. But when machines took over weaving cloth, making dishes, and stamping out metal utensils, the close relationship between the maker and the individual object was lost. The essence of craft in India from time immemorial has been that of everyday function and service. It is this perception, which is the challenge Indian crafts face in their transition from tradition to modernity.

Kamala Devi Chattopadhyaya, an untiring champion dedicated her life to reviving crafts and improving the lives of thousands of craftsmen around the country. She founded the Crafts Council of India (CCI) in 1964.

The Council seeks to identify particular crafts skills and activities which merit national recognition and revival and undertakes documentation of vanishing craft skills and facilitates and initiates practices. It identifies training supports and sources and also promotional schemes and financial facilities.

One of the new programmes undertaken is a health and craft survey to locate occupational hazards for the craftsmen. CCI approached the Voluntary Health Services, Madras to help with the survey.

In Salem district in Tamil Nadu, there were only five families who continued the tradition of making cooking utensils (Kalchattis) from soft stone. Two of the craftsmen were sponsored to attend the design centre in Bangalore where they were taught the use of machine lathe and given innovative designs for elegant tableware. Both proved quick learners and are now attempting a revival of the craft in their region.

Kinhal is an obscure village in Karnataka. It is, however, the centre of a dying craft — the making of brightly coloured toys of light wood. The plastic culture has considerably eroded the demand for the perfectly proportioned fruits and vegetables, horses and cows made by young Suresh and his friends. Suresh discovered he had an enthusiastic market in Madras where his entire stock was sold out.

In late September, child craftsmen from the Southern States came together for a camp in Madras. Though they do not belong to families practising the craft, these children have taken to learning the traditional art.

The CCI has introduced a monthly stipend scheme to encourage young talent. These children training under a master craftsman had not even imagined that their work was even considered an art form. In Madras, they looked around the art emporia to see how their creations were marketed, widened their horizons with guided tours to Mahabalipuram and the Museum and toned up their communication skills. The camp also provided them an opportunity to meet other child craftsmen and gain an alternative insight into their own crafts. Many of them had never travelled outside their villages.

Realising the need to recognise those outstanding persons upon whom the future of the craft tradition depend, and the excellence of workmanship, the CCI intends to institute annual awards in three areas, — excellence in craftsmanship, excellence in imparting of craft skills and excellence in the promotion of crafts by individuals and institutions.

In Gudiatham, the students of the Rajagopal Polytechnic had been given a holiday to attend the camp. Looking at craftsmen chiselling crude combs and the master craftsmen cutting and carving away unwanted material to form a collector's comb, evoked great pleasure.

The recent revival of interest in handwork has resurrected a wide variety of craft. Previously accepted limits of traditional materials, techniques and purposes are being expanded.

The tendency to categorise and separate objects identified as 'craft' from those considered 'art' has been heavily challenged and in many cases discarded. The 'fine art' explorations of the craft movement have brought about a merger of these traditionally separate concerns.

And for the craftsman, there is a sense of dignity and pride in a livelihood and recognition to tempt him away from succumbing to the pressures of industrialisation.



An artisan at work

V. R. Devika